

## **Week-4 Essay**

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## Introduction

In the digital age, the idea of truth has become more complicated. People often present versions of themselves that aren't entirely honest, whether in personal interactions or public appearances. In the book *Everybody Lies*, the author explores the gap between what people say in surveys and what their actual behaviors or thoughts reveal when we look at their digital footprints, things like Google searches (Davidowitz, 2017). What people admit to in conversations or questionnaires doesn't always match up with the patterns we can see in their online activity, which can reveal a truer picture of their beliefs and actions. Similarly, in *Weapons of Math Destruction*, Chapter 6, the author discusses how automated systems and algorithms are influencing job opportunities (O'Neil, 2016). These systems often filter out candidates based on factors that don't always have a real connection to how well someone would perform in a role.

## Literature Review

In Chapter 4 of *Everybody Lies*, Seth Stephens-Davidowitz examines how Google searches reveal people's hidden thoughts and desires, acting like a "digital truth serum." Unlike traditional surveys, where social pressures can influence answers, online search data offers a level of anonymity that allows people to express things they wouldn't admit publicly, such as private sexual desires, health concerns, or biases (Davidowitz, 2017). Stephens-Davidowitz contrasts what people say in surveys with what they search for online, highlighting how search histories can expose contradictions between public statements and private behaviors (Davidowitz, 2017). For example, someone may claim to hold liberal views, but their search history might reveal biases or prejudices they haven't voiced. This "digital truth serum" provides valuable insights into human behavior, helping researchers and companies better understand societal trends (Davidowitz, 2017). However, it also raises ethical questions about privacy and the potential misuse of personal data. Stephens-Davidowitz stresses the importance of using this information responsibly, given its ability to uncover deeply personal, often sensitive, details about individuals (Davidowitz, 2017).

In Chapter 6 of *Weapons of Math Destruction*, Cathy O'Neil criticizes the rise of automated hiring tools and personality tests, exposing how they perpetuate inequality while claiming to bring efficiency (O'Neil, 2016). Personality tests, designed to assess cultural fit/workplace compatibility, often exclude individuals with mental health struggles or those who deviate from rigid norms. O'Neil highlights the frustration and helplessness of job seekers navigating this process, as the systems are opaque and rarely provide feedback, leaving rejected candidates in the dark about what went wrong (O'Neil, 2016). By turning people into data points, these algorithms strip away humanity and reduce opportunities for those who need them most. O'Neil urges transparency and regulation to ensure these systems do not reinforce existing inequalities but instead create a fairer hiring process (O'Neil, 2016).

## Analysis of the Issue

In "*Everybody Lies*," the chapter illustrates how traditional surveys fail to capture the true nature of human behavior due to bias in social desirability. By contrast, digital platforms like Google provide a more candid view, as people are more honest in their search queries (Davidowitz, 2017). This discrepancy has significant implications for understanding societal issues, such as prejudices and personal regrets. Likewise, in "*Weapon of Math Destruction*" Chapter 6 examines the implications of using automated systems in hiring processes. These systems often rely on personality tests that can unfairly exclude candidates, particularly those with mental health issues or those from diverse backgrounds (O'Neil, 2016). The chapter highlights the lack of transparency and feedback in these systems, which can perpetuate inequality and discrimination.

## **Conclusion and Limitations**

Both chapters show that self-reported data and automated systems have their limits when it comes to understanding human behavior and potential. While digital data and algorithms can uncover important information, they can also introduce biases and inequalities. The data we get from digital platforms often only shows certain behaviors or groups, so it might not represent everyone. From my point of view, digital platforms can give a more honest picture of how people act, but we need to be careful. There should be more ethical guidelines and transparency, especially when algorithms are used in important areas like hiring, where they can have a big impact on people's lives.

**References**

- Davidowitz, S. S. (2017). *Everybody lies: Big data, new data, and what the internet can tell us about who we really are*. Dey Street Books.
- O'Neil, C. (2016). In *Weapons of math destruction: how big data increases inequality and threatens democracy*. Crown Publishers.